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Rebuilding Credit After a Conviction

A calm, step-by-step plan to repair your credit and avoid the scams.

Time away and a case often leave credit damaged: missed payments, closed accounts, debts sent to collections. It feels overwhelming, but credit recovers with steady, boring, consistent steps. This guide gives you the order to do them in, using the free official tools, and it flags the repair scams that prey on exactly this moment.

This is general education, not financial or legal advice. Nonprofit credit counseling can help at low or no cost if your situation is complex.

Start by seeing where you stand

- ☐ Pull all three of your credit reports for free from the official site (see sources). It is free every week now.
- ☐ Read each report. Note every account, balance, late mark, and collection.
- ☐ Circle anything that looks wrong; errors are common and you can dispute them for free.

Fix what you can, in order

- Dispute errors first, directly with each bureau, for free. Removing a wrong negative mark is the fastest win.
- Bring any current accounts up to date and keep them there. On-time payments are the single biggest factor over time.
- Deal with collections carefully; get any pay-for-deletion or settlement agreement in writing before you pay.
- Keep balances low relative to limits on any cards you have.

Rebuild, slowly and safely

- Consider a secured credit card or a credit-builder loan, used lightly and paid in full and on time.
- Add just one or two accounts and manage them perfectly. More is not better here.
- Give it time. Steady, on-time months are what rebuild a score. There is no fast button.

Avoid the scams

- No one can legally remove accurate, timely negative information. Anyone promising to erase a real debt or a true late mark is lying.
- Avoid companies charging large upfront fees to fix your credit. You can do the real steps yourself for free.
- Be careful of look-alike credit-report sites that charge for extras; use only the official free source.
- A nonprofit credit counselor is a safe, low-cost place to get a plan if you feel stuck.

My first three steps

Errors to dispute:

Accounts to bring current:

Sources and further reading: *AnnualCreditReport.com* is the only federally authorized site for free credit reports (free weekly from Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion). The FTC (consumer.ftc.gov) warns against look-alike sites that charge for other products.

This workbook is educational and reflects lived and professional experience. It is not legal advice and does not create an attorney-client relationship. Laws and procedures vary by jurisdiction and change over time. For advice about your situation, consult a licensed attorney in your state.

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